



Why choose a new direction halfway down the road?

## Change, of course

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**D**id you ever wish you could turn your professional canoe around midstream and chart another course? That's exactly what Vickie and Tom Tschantz, Angela Vagotis and Jeff and Sharon Smith did. Even though her co-workers at Aultman Hospital kidded her about becoming a cut-off-jeans-clad water tower painter, Vickie Tschantz



Repository / Ron Ray

■ **FROM PATIENT TO CLIENT.** Angela Vagotis initially pursued a career as a registered nurse. However, her medical background eventually propelled her into the practice of law.

took all the ribbing in stride when she left her job at the hospital this spring to join her husband in business.

Mrs. Tschantz was an administrative director of medical equipment at Aultman Hospital, where she'd worked 20 years. But marriage to Tom, 47, two years ago got the couple to thinking about spending the balance of their working years together in Tom's water-tower painting business.

Tom, who started his business 12 years ago, was no stranger to the concept of new challenges. He had been a Canton ironworker for 17 years but left to begin a new professional life in business for himself.

"We thought about it for a year and a half before I made the decision," said Mrs. Tschantz, who now handles the business's office management and bid work. "These are the years you get serious about retirement and your finances and you try to build a nest egg for a better retirement. This is seasonal work and when you're tied down to an 8-to-5 job like I was, I couldn't travel, which is what we hope to do during the off season."

From November through February, the Tschantzes plan to repair to the mountains of North Carolina, a place they want to retire to one day.

For now, they work the same place they live, on a 16-acre spread outside Navarre. Vickie also travels to job sites, sometimes with Tom, in Pennsylvania, Kentucky and around Ohio.

"It's a challenge, and certainly a change of lifestyle. I really enjoyed my years at Aultman. But when your job and your personal life kind of mesh together,

it's great. We hope this company is the vehicle we can use to help us for our retirement years," she said.

For Angela Vagotis, nursing seemed as if it were the perfect lifetime profession while she was earning her bachelor's degree at Bowling Green State University.

Her focus was intensive care and, following a couple of earlier positions, she eventually moved to Doctors Hospital.

It was in 1986 while working in another hospital that Miss Vagotis began to question her career decision.

"I was thinking about going for my MBA or my law degree. My (late) father (Angelo Vagotis) had always kind of thought that law would be a good field for me. He knew that it wasn't so much that I wasn't happy as a nurse but I looked to the future and I couldn't do it for the rest of my life. It wasn't challenging enough. So I applied to law school," she said.

For three years, she worked two 12-hour weekend shifts at Doctors Hospital while attending law school during the week.

"It wasn't much of a life," said Miss Vagotis, 33. "But then I took a job as a law clerk at a firm in Canton and that's when they started taking advantage of the fact that I was a nurse. That's how I started to learn about medical malpractice."

Today, medical malpractice — representing the injured — is her focus. She opened her own Canton practice in 1992. Her nursing background comes back into play every day.

"There's not a day goes by that I'm not looking at a medical record and using what I learned,"

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## Change

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she said.

Miss Vagotis, a North Canton resident who will be married in August, is certain her decision was a sound one. Her father unfortunately did not live to see her accomplishments. He died eight months before her law-school graduation.

"It was a good decision. Nursing is a very task-oriented field and nurses follow physicians' orders," she explained. "In the law, as the attorney, you're setting out a plan for each case, making decisions for each case. That's not to say that nurses don't make decisions, though, they do it every day."

Entrepreneur Jeff Smith, 35, puts in six hours a day at his Blimpie Subs and Salads franchises in Canton and then heads to Hannon Electric where he works the afternoon shift as a machinist.

His wife of 12 years, Sharon, took the professional leap, leaving her job as executive secretary to the owner of several nursing homes, in order to manage the couple's restaurant operation.

The Smiths have only been Blimpie franchisees for a few years, but they agree the rewards have been worth the risk.

With Jeff working afternoons and Sharon, 32, working days, they functioned for years, seeing each other only on the weekends. During those times, they'd discuss the possibility of owning a

business and research eventually convinced them that a Blimpie franchise was the right move. The only disappointment was that they'd hoped to open one in Strasburg, where they lived.

"We thought it would be nice to have a business down here, but Canton is more of a thriving market. This little town (Strasburg) didn't meet the criteria," Jeff said.

And, though Jeff had begun his working years in a Dutch Pantry restaurant in 1978, he never dreamed he'd make his living building submarine sandwiches. Apparently, the Smiths are naturals. An affinity for the work and long hours, they say, have yielded success beyond their expectations.

Of 28 franchises in Northeast Ohio, the Smiths' two Canton restaurants have been judged the best. They are one of five national finalists of a field of 1,500 for franchise of the year.

Success has not been without cost, Jeff said. When his mother became ill last year, he was torn between hospital visits and his obligations to the business and his Hannon job. Her death, he said, was extremely difficult for him.

The upside of the operation, Sharon said, is that she gets to see her husband more now that their business interests are dovetailed.

"When we opened the store, I just knew that one of us had to be there. I knew I had to quit my job. But it wasn't a hard decision," said Sharon. "This was our business and we knew we were going to make it work."